POLICY FRAMEWORK

The Levels Of Ambition (LOA)

Transition Architecture

The government has committed to Level of Ambition 2 by 2028 without an institutional transformation plan. Only fifty-four of 130 Commission recommendations were completed in four years, and the rate is slowing. The gap is not budget, as Ireland could fund LOA 3 from a single year's surplus. The gap is institutional bandwidth. This paper provides the roadmap the spending commitment lacks.

Security Ireland

KEY FINDING

> Ireland's Commission on the Defence Forces produced one of the most honest capability assessments of any European state. LOA 1 — the current state — is 'inadequate for the defence of Ireland.' LOA 2 — the government's target by 2028 — would give Ireland the ability to monitor its airspace and maritime domain. LOA 3 is 'the first level at which Ireland could defend itself.' The government has committed spending: €1.7 billion in capital over 2026–2030, a record €1.5 billion Budget 2026. But it has not committed an institutional transformation plan, leading to the rate of implementation slowing, not accelerating. Personnel strength is at a fifty-year low. The procurement system has never built first-generation capabilities. The transition from LOA 1 to LOA 2 is a spending challenge. However, the transition from LOA 2 to LOA 3 is an institutional transformation challenge. Each requires a different kind of reform.

Three Levels of Ambition (LOA)

Figure 1: Three Levels of Ambition defined by the Commission on the Defence Forces. LOA 1 (current): 'inadequate.' LOA 2 (target 2028): monitoring capability. LOA 3: self-defence. The Chief of Staff views everything through an LOA 3 lens, but no roadmap exists.

LOA stands for Level of Ambition — the framework the Commission on the Defence Forces created in 2022 to define three tiers of military capability for Ireland, from the current state through to self-defence. The three levels now structure the entire Irish defence debate. LOA 1 is the current state: Ireland cannot detect aircraft entering its airspace, cannot detect submarines in its EEZ, cannot arm its naval vessels, and cannot sustain its existing force structure at 7,531 personnel against an establishment of 9,739. The Commission's own language is striking: 'inadequate for the defence of Ireland.'

LOA 2 is the government's target by 2028: primary radar, improved naval capacity, a counter-drone system, and a reformed reserve. LOA 2 would give Ireland the ability to monitor its airspace and maritime domain — functions that every other European state already possesses. The capital budget has been raised to €1.7 billion over 2026–2030 to support this transition.

LOA 3 is 'the first level at which Ireland could defend itself.' It would require ground-based air defence, meaningful naval combat capability, anti-submarine warfare capacity, a unified intelligence agency, and personnel strength well above current establishment. Lieutenant General Rossa Mulcahy, the Chief of Staff, has stated that he views everything 'through an LOA 3 lens.' But no budget, timeline, or institutional roadmap exists for LOA 3.

Implementation velocity

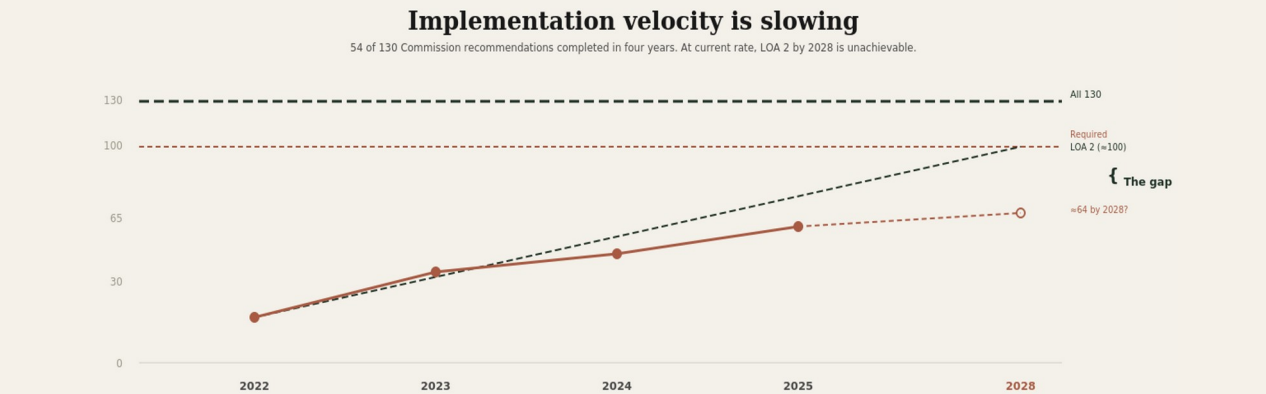

Figure 2: Implementation velocity. 54 of 130 recommendations completed in four years. The rate is slowing. At current trajectory, approximately 64 recommendations will be complete by 2028 — well short of the ~100 needed for LOA 2. The gap between the required trajectory and the actual trajectory is widening.

As of December 2025, fifty-four of the Commission's 130 recommendations have been completed — roughly forty per cent in nearly four years. The implementation rate peaked in the first two years and has since decelerated. At the current trajectory, approximately 64 recommendations will be complete by 2028 — falling well short of the approximately 100 required for LOA 2 to be meaningfully achieved.

The deceleration is not random. The early completions were the easier ones: policy documents, governance reforms, organisational changes that required decisions but not capability builds. The remaining recommendations increasingly involve first-generation capability acquisition — radar systems, naval armament, counter-drone technology, personnel reform — that the procurement system has never delivered. Each remaining recommendation is institutionally harder than the ones already completed.

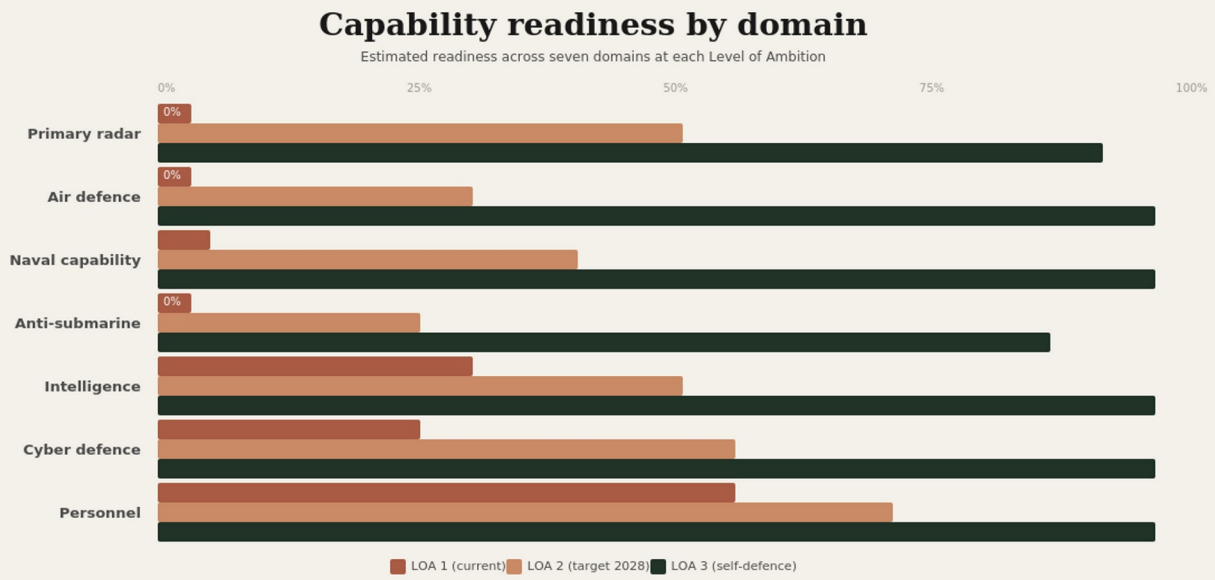

Figure 3: Capability readiness across seven domains at each Level of Ambition. LOA 1 shows near-zero capability in radar, air defence, and anti-submarine warfare. LOA 2 addresses monitoring. LOA 3 is the minimum for self-defence. The visualisation makes the scale of the gap visible.

The bandwidth problem

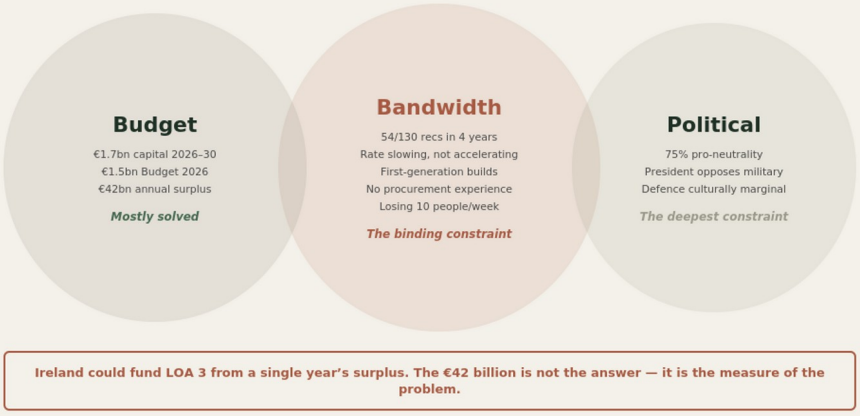

Figure 4: Three constraints on the LOA transition. Budget is largely solved (€1.7bn capital, €42bn annual surplus). Institutional bandwidth is the binding constraint. Political economy is the deepest. The €42 billion surplus is not the answer — it is the measure of the problem.

The coordination architecture framework distinguishes between budget constraints and bandwidth constraints. Ireland's transition is **bandwidth-constrained**, not **budget-constrained**. The €1.7 billion capital programme and €42 billion annual surplus demonstrate that money is available, but what is not available is the institutional system's capacity to absorb transformation at the speed the situation demands.

The bandwidth constraint has five dimensions:

First, no procurement experience: the system has never built first-generation capabilities. There is no template, no institutional memory, and no established supplier relationships for radar, counter-drone, or naval combat systems.

Second, the personnel death spiral: at 7,531 — a fifty-year low — the Defence Forces cannot staff existing platforms, let alone new ones. A Private 3 Star salary starts at roughly €40,000 in a country where housing near barracks averages €1,800 per month. Recruitment competes with multinational technology companies headquartered in Dublin.

Third, the commander-in-chief problem: the President, constitutionally the Supreme Commander, has publicly opposed the military's existence.

Fourth, the cultural constraint: 75% public support for neutrality understood as requiring no military capability.

Fifth, the system must maintain existing operations while simultaneously building capabilities it has never possessed, through institutions that were never designed for transformation.

The transformation roadmap

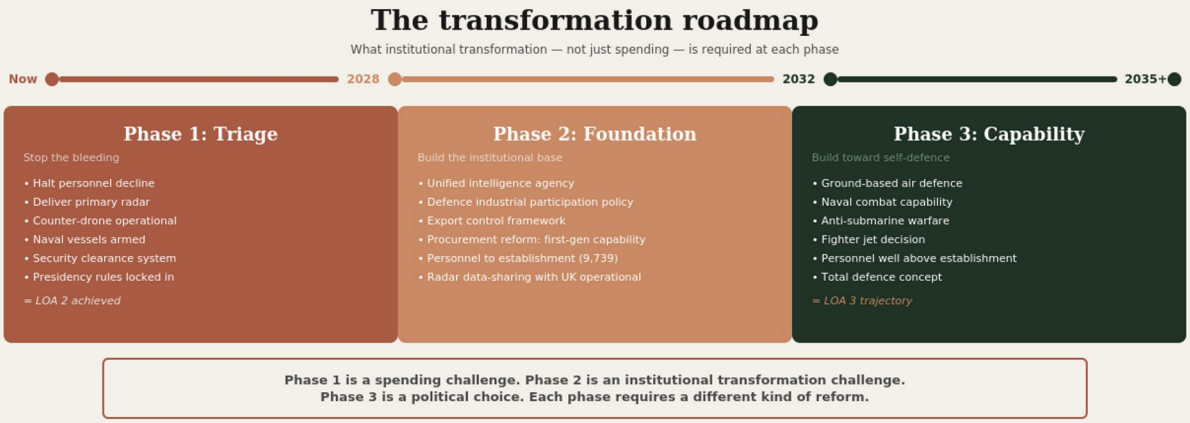

Figure 5: Three phases of transformation. Phase 1 (now–2028): triage — halt the bleeding, deliver LOA 2 capabilities. Phase 2 (2028–2032): foundation — build the institutional base. Phase 3 (2032+): capability — move toward LOA 3 and self-defence. Each phase requires a different kind of reform.

Phase 1: Triage (now–2028)

Phase 1 is primarily a spending and procurement challenge. In short, the money exists, and the task is to convert it into delivered capability through a procurement system that has never done this. If Phase 1 succeeds, Ireland achieves LOA 2: it can monitor its own airspace and maritime domain. The free-rider accusation loses its sharpest edge.

Activities: Stop the personnel decline. Deliver primary radar. Make counter-drone technology operational. Arm existing naval vessels. Establish the security clearance system. Lock in the EU Presidency rules (EDIP, SAFE, MFF domain naming).

Phase 2: Foundation (2028–2032)

Phase 2 is an institutional transformation challenge. It cannot be solved with money alone. It requires new institutions, reformed processes, and sustained political commitment across at least one electoral cycle.

Activities: Build the institutional architecture that Phase 1 lacked. Establish a unified intelligence agency. Develop a defence industrial participation policy. Build export control infrastructure. Reform procurement to handle first-generation capability builds. Bring personnel to establishment strength (9,739). Integrate radar data-sharing with the UK.

Phase 3: Capability (2032+)

Phase 3 is a political choice. It requires a society that accepts defence capability as a function of the state, not a cultural aberration. This is the deepest transformation and the longest timeline.

Activities: With the institutional foundation in place, begin building toward ground-based air defence. Naval combat capability. Anti-submarine warfare. The fighter jet decision. Personnel well above establishment. A total defence concept integrating civilian and military preparedness.

Figure 6: What each phase unlocks. Phase 1 ends the free-rider accusation and makes the Presidency credible. Phase 2 builds the institutional architecture for sustained capability. Phase 3 achieves self-defence. Each phase changes Ireland's position in EU negotiations, with partners, and in public discourse.

THE BOTTOM LINE

The government has committed the spending for LOA 2, but it has not committed the institutional transformation plan, and the rate of implementation is slowing because the remaining recommendations are institutionally harder than the ones already completed. The roadmap this paper provides organises the transition into three phases, each requiring a different kind of reform: spending (Phase 1), institutional transformation (Phase 2), and political choice (Phase 3). The Presidency Desk series addresses Phase 1 from the EU side — ensuring the rules being written now recognise Ireland's contribution and fund its transition. This paper addresses Phases 2 and 3 from the domestic side. Together, they provide the complete architecture for Ireland's security transition.

A NOTE ON METHOD

This paper applies the coordination architecture framework to Ireland's LOA transition. It draws on the Commission on the Defence Forces report (2022), departmental implementation data, public capability assessments, and the framework's distinction between optimisation architectures (which maintain stability) and transformation architectures (which reorganise under pressure). Ireland's system is neither: it is an architecture optimised for the absence of a capability it now needs to build. The roadmap is designed to address this structural mismatch.

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